

Guide to distinguish medical vs behavioral causes and proven intervention techniques — Action Checklist

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CONDUCT PHYSICAL HEALTH CHECKS

- ☐ **Conduct Physical Health Checks:** Assess your cat's mobility and jumping ability for pain indicators such as hesitation before leaping, awkward landings, or using furniture to boost herself up instead of leaping directly.
- ☐ **Conduct Physical Health Checks:** Evaluate your cat's grooming habits by comparing current behavior to normal, noting decreases, increases, or overgrooming that causes fur loss or skin irritation in specific areas.
- ☐ **Conduct Physical Health Checks:** Monitor your cat's litterbox habits for warning signs including straining, crying, unusual time spent in the box, deposits outside the box, or changes in stool consistency and frequency.
- ☐ **Conduct Physical Health Checks:** Observe your cat's resting posture for signs of discomfort such as frequently shifting positions, lying flat and extended instead of curled up, or avoiding specific body positions.

DOCUMENT BEHAVIORAL PATTERNS

- ☐ **Document Behavioral Patterns:** Establish a baseline of what normal behavior looks like for your specific cat before assessing changes, because two cats in the same household can have completely different normal baselines.
- ☐ **Document Behavioral Patterns:** Build an escalation timeline that documents when the biting started, how it has progressed, and what circumstances preceded each escalation, because patterns reveal triggers you cannot see in your head.
- ☐ **Document Behavioral Patterns:** Learn to recognize your cat's pre-attack body language by watching for subtle warning signals like ear position, tail movement, and whisker changes before aggression escalates to biting.
- ☐ **Document Behavioral Patterns:** Map your cat's triggers across four environmental domains including resources, social dynamics, environmental stressors, and daily routine changes to identify what provokes the aggressive episodes.

TAKE ACTION WITH YOUR VET

- ☐ **Take Action With Your Vet:** Schedule a veterinary appointment as the first priority after completing your physical assessment, because pain is the most common trigger for sudden aggression and must be ruled out first.
 - ☐ **Take Action With Your Vet:** Bring a prepared agenda to your veterinary visit that includes your completed 12-point pain assessment checklist, your escalation timeline, and specific observations about what you have witnessed.
 - ☐ **Take Action With Your Vet:** Ask your veterinarian to conduct a thorough pain evaluation during the exam, because cats hide pain brilliantly and what looks like a bad attitude is often a cat protecting herself from invisible discomfort.
 - ☐ **Take Action With Your Vet:** Create a targeted intervention plan that addresses the specific type of aggression your cat is displaying, because each of the six core aggression categories requires a different intervention approach.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.